FERRO // HAUTE ATELIER BENGALURU

SALON 05 FINALIST EVALUATION - OFFICIAL SIMULATION TRANSCRIPT

CANDIDATE: ANJALI KRISHNAMURTHY | DOSSIER #0847 | DATE: 15 OCT 2026

PLATFORM:	Google Meet (Video Conference Sync)
SESSION DURATION:	1 Hour 58 Minutes (09:02 - 11:00 IST)
EVALUATION PANEL:	Mithun S. (Creative Dir), Rhea Kapoor (Design), Arjun Desai (Ops)
CANDIDATE PROFILE:	Age 23 - Self-taught & Apprentice - 5 Submitted Silhouettes
SECURITY CLEARANCE:	INTERNAL ONLY - Salon 05 Jury & Executive Panel

PART I - OPENING & FIRST IMPRESSIONS

TIMECODE WINDOW: [09:02 - 09:18]

Mithun: Anjali, hey - can you hear us alright? Video looks good on our end.

Anjali: Yes, perfect - hi! Thank you so much for having me. I've been thinking about this conversation for days, honestly.

Mithun: Good nervous or bad nervous?

Anjali: Good nervous. The kind where you can't sleep because you're excited, not because you're scared.

Mithun: That's the right answer. So - before we get into the formal stuff, I want to set the tone. This isn't a stress interview. We're not here to trick you or catch you off guard. We genuinely want to understand how you think, how you see clothes, how you see the world through fabric and form. If we're going to work together every day in this atelier, we need to know if the chemistry is there - even through a screen. Okay?

Anjali: Okay. I appreciate that.

Mithun: Great. Rhea, Arjun - introduce yourselves?

Rhea: Hey Anjali. I'm Rhea - I run design and pattern architecture here. Which basically means I'm the person who has to figure out how to actually construct the insane things Mithun dreams up. *[laughs]* I'll be asking you a lot about technical process, materials, how you think through a garment from sketch to finished piece.

Arjun: And I'm Arjun. I handle operations, brand strategy, production logistics. I'm the one who makes sure the clothes actually get made, shipped, and that the numbers work. I'll be less about the art and more about how you work - your habits, your pace, how you handle pressure, how you collaborate.

Anjali: Got it. That's a really balanced panel.

Mithun: That's the idea. So, Anjali - let's start with the obvious. Tell us about yourself. Not the résumé version. The real version. Who are you, and why do you make clothes?

Anjali: Okay. So - I'm twenty-three. I'm from Mysuru originally, grew up there until I was seventeen, then moved to Bengaluru. I don't have a fashion degree. I want to say that upfront because I know it's a thing people wonder about. I dropped out of a B.Com programme after one year because I was spending every evening in my room draping fabric on a dress form I'd bought secondhand from a tailor on Commercial Street. My parents were - they were confused, honestly. Not angry. Just confused. Like, "You want to do what? Sew?"

Mithun: *[smiles]* I know that look.

Anjali: Right? But I'd been sketching since I was maybe thirteen or fourteen. Not fashion sketches, initially. I was drawing people. I was obsessed with how people carried themselves - the way my grandmother tied her sari, nine yards, Coorg style, tucked between the legs like trousers. The way the neighbourhood tailor's son wore his father's shirt with the sleeves rolled four times. I was drawing posture, really. And at some point the posture and the clothing became inseparable in my head.

Rhea: That's interesting - you came to garments through the body, not through the garment itself.

Anjali: Exactly. I still think that way. I don't start with "I want to make a coat." I start with "What does a person's shoulder do when they're walking fast through rain?" And then the coat designs itself around that movement.

Arjun: So you're self-taught? Entirely?

Anjali: Mostly. I apprenticed - informally, nothing official - with a master tailor in Jayanagar for about eight months. His name is Raghunath. He's seventy-one, been tailoring since he was fourteen. He does bridal blouses, mostly. Incredibly precise hand-stitching. He taught me more about construction in eight months than I think I'd have learned in three years of college. How to read a body just by looking at someone standing in a doorway. How to cut without chalk marks once you understand the grain of the fabric. How to press a seam so it disappears.

Mithun: We actually do something similar here. We call it "zero-mark cutting." Rhea can tell you more about it later, but - that resonates.

Anjali: I saw that term on your website, actually, and I - honestly, I got chills. Because I thought it was just this old man's personal method, and then I see a brand using the same philosophy and it felt like a sign.

Rhea: Raghunath sounds like someone we should meet.

Anjali: He'd love that. He doesn't know what FERRO is, but he'd respect the work. He respects anyone who respects the needle.

PART II - PORTFOLIO DEEP DIVE

TIMECODE WINDOW: [09:18 - 09:52]

Mithun: Okay, let's look at your submission. You submitted five silhouettes for Salon 05. We've got them pulled up on our end - Rhea has her annotated copies too. Walk us through them. Start wherever you want.

Anjali: Can I start with the one I'm most proud of?

Mithun: Absolutely.

Anjali: So this is the third directive - Indian Heritage Reimagined. I did a structured drape piece inspired by the Ilkal sari from North Karnataka. The Ilkal has this very specific technique called "tope teni" - it's a method of joining the body of the sari to the pallu using an interlocking weave. It's not stitched, it's woven together. And I kept thinking - what if a jacket did that? What if the front panel and the back panel weren't sewn together at the side seams but were interlocked through a woven join?

Rhea: *[leaning forward]* Wait. So structurally, you're saying the side seam doesn't exist?

Anjali: The side seam doesn't exist. Instead, there's a three-centimetre woven interlock zone running from the underarm to the hip. I did it in a heavyweight handloom cotton - a thick Ilkal weave I sourced from a weaver in Bagalkot. It took me four attempts to get the tension right because handloom cotton behaves differently from mill cotton. It pulls. It has memory.

Rhea: And how does it drape? Because an interlocked join is going to be stiffer than a pressed-open seam.

Anjali: It is stiffer, and that's actually the point. The stiffness at the side creates this - I call it an "architectural flare." The jacket doesn't fall the way a tailored jacket falls. It holds its own shape, almost like a carapace, but when the person moves - when they twist or reach - the interlock flexes just enough. It breathes. It's rigid and alive at the same time.

Mithun: This is the sketch here - *[screen-shares the print]* - and you did the sitting pose directive with this same piece?

Anjali: Yes. Because I wanted to show that the structured drape doesn't fight the body when you sit. That's usually where stiff garments fail - they ride up, they bunch, they crease badly. But because the interlock has that micro-flex, it redistributes the tension across the woven zone instead of concentrating it at a single seam point.

Mithun: Rhea, what's your read on the construction feasibility?

Rhea: Honestly? This is ambitious. A woven interlock on a jacket at this scale - I've seen it done on accessories, on bags, but on a full side-panel jacket? That's atelier-level handwork. You'd need a weaver on-site or a very close partnership with one. But the thinking is extraordinary. The fact that she's eliminated a seam and replaced it with a textile technique - that's exactly the kind of bridge between craft and haute construction that we talk about here.

Anjali: I actually brought a swatch - let me hold it up to the camera. Can you see this?

Mithun: Yeah, bring it closer - there we go.

Anjali: *[holds fabric up to webcam]* This is a ten-centimetre section of the interlock zone. You can see the join here - the warp threads from the front panel cross into the weft of the back panel. If I pull it - gently - you can see the flex.

Rhea: *[leaning into screen]* Oh, that's beautiful. Even through the camera you can see the hand on it. Where did you say this was woven?

Anjali: Bagalkot. A small collective - three women, two looms. They were confused when I explained what I wanted. They're used to doing tope teni at the pallu junction of a sari, not on a random rectangle of fabric a twenty-three-year-old showed up with. But they figured it out. Took us two days of back-and-forth on the loom.

Arjun: Can I ask a logistical question? If we were to produce this - even in limited atelier quantities, say ten to fifteen units - could that collective handle the volume? What's their turnaround?

Anjali: Honestly, at their current capacity, maybe three interlock panels a week. So for fifteen units, you're looking at five weeks just for the side panels. But I think with a second loom and a fourth person, that could come down to three weeks.

Arjun: And you've maintained that relationship? They'd work with us?

Anjali: I paid them fairly and brought them jaggery and bananas, so yes, I think they like me. *[laughs]* But seriously - yes, I've stayed in touch. They're excited to do something different from saris.

Mithun: Okay. Walk us through the Duo Look.

Anjali: The Duo Look - the paired piece - this one was the most personal for me. I designed it around my sister and me. We're very different physically - she's five-two, I'm five-seven. She's curvy, I'm angular. And I wanted to make a pair of looks that were clearly from the same family - same DNA - but that honoured each body's architecture completely differently.

So the first look is a long, columnar tunic with exaggerated dropped shoulders and a mandarin collar. Very vertical. It's for the taller, leaner frame - it amplifies the length. The second look is a cropped, wide-cut blouse with a high waistline and a voluminous A-line skirt that starts at the narrowest point of the torso. It's for the shorter, curvier frame - it creates proportion through strategic volume.

But here's the connection: both pieces are cut from the same bolt of fabric - a deep indigo handwoven khadi - and they share a single motif. A hand-embroidered constellation pattern along the hem of the tunic and the waistband of the skirt. So when the two people stand together, the constellations align. Literally. The stars on one garment continue onto the other.

Mithun: That's... that's cinema. That's not just clothing, that's storytelling.

Anjali: That's what I want to do. I want people to look at two strangers on the street wearing FERRO and wonder if they're part of the same story.

Rhea: The technical question I have is about the embroidery alignment. If you're cutting from the same bolt, the embroidery has to be planned before the cut, not after. You're essentially mapping the constellation across the full width of the fabric and then cutting the two patterns from it so the motif carries across. Is that how you did it?

Anjali: Yes. I drew the constellation on the full bolt first - in tailor's chalk - and then positioned both pattern pieces over it so that the stars fell where I needed them. Cut, and then embroidered over the chalk lines. It's - it's basically pattern engineering in reverse. You start with the surface design and derive the cut from it, instead of the other way around.

Rhea: *[to Mithun]* She's thinking in systems, not in garments. That's rare.

Mithun: Tell us about the chromatic accent piece.

Anjali: So the directive was vibrant colour. And I - I'll be honest, I struggle with colour. I work in indigo, black, ivory, grey. That's my comfort zone. So I treated this directive as a challenge to myself. I designed a draped vest - almost like a waistcoat but with one long asymmetric tail - in a saffron silk twill. And the colour isn't uniform. I hand-dyed it myself using actual saffron - the spice - mixed with turmeric and a lac mordant. So the saffron deepens from a pale gold at the collar to a burnt orange at the tail. It's a gradient, but it's organic, not digital. Every piece would be slightly different because the dye absorption is never identical.

Arjun: Natural dyeing. That's inherently variable. How do you handle quality control when every piece is unique?

Anjali: I think you reframe the conversation. You don't call it inconsistency - you call it individuality. Each vest is literally one-of-one. The customer isn't buying a product; they're buying a specific piece of saffron-dyed silk that will never be replicated. That's the luxury, isn't it? The unreplicability.

Mithun: *[quietly]* That's the exact word we use internally. Unreplicability.

Anjali: I read your manifesto maybe twelve times.

Mithun: It shows. Rhea, you want to go into the pattern sketch details?

Rhea: Yes - Anjali, let's talk about your hat and accessories directive. I noticed you incorporated the hat as a structural extension of the garment rather than a separate accessory. Walk me through that.

Anjali: Right. So my fifth silhouette - the Global Cultural Heritage piece - is inspired by Mongolian deel robes. The deel has this beautiful standing collar that wraps high around the neck. I extended that collar upward and forward so that it becomes a structured headpiece - almost like a soft helmet or a high-backed bonnet. The "hat" isn't separate from the garment; it's grown from it. It's the collar that kept going.

The bow is integrated at the back of the neckline where the collar transitions into the headpiece - a long trailing silk bow that falls down the spine. And the necklace - I designed it as a rigid, hammered brass collar piece that sits at the base of the extended collar, acting as both jewellery and structural support for the headpiece.

Rhea: So you've unified all the accessory mandates - hat, bow, necklace - into a single garment system.

Anjali: Exactly. I don't believe in accessories as afterthoughts. If a garment needs a hat, then the hat should feel like it was always part of the garment's body. Otherwise you're just decorating. And I'm not interested in decoration.

Rhea: The patterns - the directive asked for pattern integration as well.

Anjali: Yes. The deel-inspired robe has a hand-block-printed geometric pattern across the front panel. I worked with a block printer in Jaipur - I sent him reference images of Mongolian geometric motifs and he carved a new block specifically for this. It's a repeating angular spiral - very architectural, very hard-edged - printed in a metallic bronze ink on raw silk.

Mithun: You went to Jaipur for a block?

Anjali: I didn't go physically - I couldn't afford the trip. I did everything over WhatsApp video calls. Four calls, about two hours total, guiding his hand on the carving. He was patient. I think he thought I was a bit mad, but he carved it beautifully.

Arjun: That's resourceful. You worked within constraints and still got the result you needed.

Anjali: That's what not having money teaches you. You learn to make the phone call instead of the trip.

PART III - TECHNICAL PROFICIENCY & PROCESS

TIMECODE WINDOW: [09:52 - 10:28]

Rhea: Okay, Anjali. I'm going to get technical now. I want to understand your actual making process. Let's say I gave you a brief right now - a deconstructed blazer in a mid-weight wool crepe. Walk me through your process from brief to finished garment.

Anjali: First thing I do is not sketch. I know that sounds counterintuitive, but I don't start on paper. I start with the fabric. I need to touch the wool crepe first. I need to understand its drape, its memory, its bias behaviour. I'll spend maybe an hour just holding it, folding it, draping it over my shoulder, sitting in it, walking with it. I want to know what the fabric wants to do before I tell it what to do.

Rhea: That's a very Japanese approach. Miyake-influenced?

Anjali: Miyake, yes, but also just - Raghunath. The tailor I apprenticed with. He would never cut a fabric he hadn't spent time with. He'd say, "The cloth knows its shape before you do. Your job is to listen."

Rhea: Okay, so you've listened to the fabric. Then what?

Anjali: Then I drape directly on the form. I don't do flat pattern drafting first - I know some designers do, and I respect that method, but my brain works three-dimensionally. I'll pin and drape and cut on the form, and from that draped toile, I'll extract the flat pattern. So my flat pattern is derived from the drape, not the other way around.

Rhea: That's how we work here, actually. Drape-first, pattern-second.

Anjali: Really?

Rhea: Really. Mithun insists on it. He says flat patterns are "blueprints for buildings nobody wants to live in."

Anjali: *[laughs]* That's - that's exactly how it feels to me. A flat pattern is a prediction. A drape is a conversation.

Rhea: So you've draped the toile. Now - you said deconstructed blazer. What does "deconstructed" mean to you? Because everyone uses that word differently.

Anjali: To me, deconstruction isn't about removing things. It's about revealing structure. A traditional blazer hides its bones - the canvas, the pad stitching, the shoulder construction, the taping. A deconstructed blazer doesn't remove those things; it makes them visible. It says: look at how I'm built. The seam allowances face outward. The canvas is exposed at the lapel. The shoulder line shows the dart manipulation instead of hiding it.

It's architectural transparency. You're turning the garment inside-out without literally turning it inside-out.

Rhea: Beautiful answer. Now - and this is important - tell me about a time a garment failed. Something you made that just didn't work.

Anjali: Oh god, yes. *[laughs]* The Ilkal jacket, actually. Not the final version - the second iteration. I tried to do the woven interlock using machine-spun cotton instead of handloom because it was cheaper and I thought it would behave the same. It didn't. Machine cotton is too uniform - it doesn't have the irregularity that gives handloom its micro-texture. The interlock was too tight. It didn't flex. When I put it on the form and tried to simulate sitting, the entire side seam zone just - buckled. Like a piece of corrugated cardboard. It was awful.

Rhea: What did you learn?

Anjali: That material integrity isn't negotiable. You can't substitute the soul of a fabric and expect the garment to still have a soul. I was trying to save money and I nearly killed the best idea I've ever had. After that, I went back to the Bagalkot weavers and paid the real price and it worked.

Rhea: Good. One more technical question. How do you handle fit across different body types? Especially if you're draping on a standard form but the garment needs to work on a range of bodies?

Anjali: I drape on two forms. I have a size eight form and a size fourteen form - both secondhand, both slightly imperfect, which I actually prefer because real bodies are imperfect. I drape the initial concept on the size eight, but before I finalise, I re-drape on the fourteen to see where the design breaks. And it always breaks somewhere. A neckline that's elegant on a smaller frame might choke on a larger frame. A sleeve head that sits beautifully on narrow shoulders might pull on broad shoulders.

So I design for the break point. I find where the design fails on the larger form and I re-engineer from there. Usually that means building in more ease, adjusting dart placement, or changing the grain alignment. The goal is that the garment looks intentional on every body - not like a scaled-up version of a smaller design.

Rhea: *[to Mithun and Arjun]* This is the answer I was hoping for. Most candidates design for one body and assume grading will take care of the rest. She designs for the failure case first. That's production-aware thinking.

Arjun: Anjali, I want to shift gears a bit. Can I ask about your daily working habits?

Anjali: Of course.

Arjun: What does a normal working day look like for you right now?

Anjali: I wake up around six. I do a thirty-minute walk - not for exercise, really, just to look at people. I live near Jayanagar 4th Block, and the morning crowd is incredible for people-watching. The vegetable vendors in their saris, the tech workers in their oversized hoodies, the school kids. I'm observing how fabric moves on real bodies in real life. I get home, shower, eat, and I'm at my workspace by eight-thirty. I work until about one, break for lunch and a nap - I'm a firm believer in the afternoon nap - and then I work again from three to seven or eight. Some nights I'll do a late session from nine to midnight if I'm in the flow.

Arjun: So you're roughly a ten to twelve hour worker?

Anjali: On average, yes. But those hours aren't all cutting and stitching. Some of them are just thinking. Sitting with a piece and staring at it. Drawing variations. Reading. I read a lot of architectural theory, actually - Tadao Ando, Peter Zumthor, Balkrishna Doshi. I find more fashion inspiration in architecture than in fashion magazines.

Arjun: How do you handle criticism of your work?

Anjali: Badly at first. Honestly. *[smiles]* There's always a moment when someone critiques something I've made where my first internal reaction is defensive - "You don't understand what I was trying to do." But I've trained myself to wait. To sit with the critique for at least twenty-four hours before responding. And usually, after twenty-four hours, I can see the truth in it. Even if the critique is wrong about the specific thing, it's usually pointing at a real problem I hadn't seen.

Raghunath was brutal with his feedback. He'd look at a seam and just shake his head and walk away. No words. Just... [mimics head shake]. And at first I'd be devastated. But eventually I learned that his silence was the most honest form of critique. He wouldn't waste words on something that wasn't ready.

Arjun: What about working in a team? You've mostly worked alone. How do you think you'd adapt to a studio environment where four or five people might be contributing to the same piece?

Anjali: I think I'd thrive in it, but I know I'd have to unlearn some habits. When you work alone, you develop a very personal shorthand - you know where every tool is, you have your own system for labelling muslins, your own way of pressing. In a shared studio, that has to become a shared language. I'm ready for that. Actually, I'm hungry for it. The hardest part of working alone isn't the workload - it's the silence. I want collaborators. I want someone to look at my drape and say, "What if the shoulder line was three centimetres further back?" and for that to be a better answer than the one I had.

Arjun: Last one from me in this section - what's your relationship with deadlines?

Anjali: I respect them. I don't like them - nobody likes them - but I respect them. The Salon 05 submission deadline was a good example. I had three of my five sketches done a week before the deadline. The fourth took me four days of agonising. The fifth - the chromatic accent piece - I finished at eleven PM the night before. Not because I was procrastinating, but because the dye process on the saffron silk took longer than I expected and I needed the physical swatch to finish the sketch accurately. I submitted with an hour to spare.

Arjun: Cutting it close.

Anjali: Cutting it close, yes. But I submitted. And the piece was right. I'd rather be late and right than early and wrong, but ideally I want to be on time and right. That takes practice and planning, and I'm still learning.

PART IV - DESIGN PHILOSOPHY & CULTURAL VISION

TIMECODE WINDOW: [10:28 - 10:52]

Mithun: Anjali, I want to talk about philosophy now. We've seen what you can make. I want to understand what you believe. What is fashion for?

Anjali: *[pauses]* Fashion is armour. Not in the aggressive sense - not like a shield against the world. More like - when you put on the right piece of clothing, something shifts in your posture, in your confidence, in the way you occupy space. The garment gives you permission to be a version of yourself you couldn't access without it. Fashion is the bridge between who you are privately and who you present publicly. And high fashion - good high fashion - doesn't just bridge that gap. It dissolves it. It makes the private self and the public self the same person.

Mithun: That's philosophically aligned with how we think here. We say, "Dress the person they're becoming, not the person they are."

Anjali: Yes. That resonates deeply. And I think - I think Indian fashion specifically is at an inflection point. We have this incredible heritage - millennia of textile craft, weaving traditions, dyeing techniques that the rest of the world literally cannot replicate. But for a long time, "Indian fashion" meant either traditional wear or bad copies of European trends. We were either preserving or imitating. Nobody was synthesising.

And I think FERRO represents that synthesis. You're not an "Indian brand" in the ethnic-wear sense. You're not a "Western brand" based in India. You're something new - a brand that speaks a global language but with an Indian accent. And I want to be part of building that accent.

Mithun: What does luxury mean to you? Specifically.

Anjali: Luxury is the opposite of convenience. Everything in modern life is designed to be fast, easy, replaceable. Luxury says: this took time. This required skill. This cannot be replicated by a machine or an algorithm. When someone holds a garment and can feel the hours in it - the hand-stitching, the hand-dyeing, the hand-woven interlock - that's luxury. It's proof of human labour and human thought. In a world that's increasingly automated, that proof becomes more and more valuable.

Mithun: Do you follow what's happening with AI-generated fashion?

Anjali: I do. And I'm not afraid of it - I think AI is an incredible tool for ideation, for colourway generation, for reference gathering. But AI can't feel fabric. It can't tell you that a handloom cotton has more "memory" than a machine cotton. It can't sit with a weaver in Bagalkot for two days negotiating tension. The physical, tactile, human part of making - that's irreplaceable. And I think the brands that survive the next decade will be the ones that double down on that humanity.

Rhea: Where do you see yourself in five years, design-wise? What kind of work do you want to be doing?

Anjali: In five years, I want to have developed a personal vocabulary - a set of techniques and silhouettes that are recognisably mine, even within a larger house. Like how you can look at a McQueen sleeve and know it's McQueen, even if his name isn't on it. I want to develop signature construction methods - the woven interlock is the beginning of that - that become associated with my hand.

But I also want to mentor. I was lucky to find Raghunath. Most young makers aren't. I want to be the person that someone finds. I want to teach the way he taught me - through doing, through showing, through shutting up and letting someone make mistakes and learn from them.

Mithun: That's long-term thinking. I like it.

Anjali: I read your competition statement about nurturing the future of fashion. I took that very literally. I don't just want to be nurtured - I want to eventually nurture others.

Mithun: Let me ask you something harder. What do you think FERRO does wrong? Or could do better? You've seen the website, the manifesto, presumably some of our early lookbook imagery. Where do we fall short?

Anjali: *[long pause]* Can I be honest?

Mithun: I'll be disappointed if you're not.

Anjali: Your accessory language is underdeveloped. The garments are extraordinary - the overcoat, the structural pieces - but the accessories feel secondary. The eyewear, the bag - they're good, but they feel like they were designed after the garments, not alongside them. In a true atelier system, the accessories should be born from the same design logic as the clothes. If your garments are about architectural volume and kinetic drape, your accessories should embody that same philosophy at a smaller scale. Right now, they feel like a different vocabulary.

Mithun: *[glances off-screen at Rhea]*

Rhea: She's not wrong.

Mithun: She's not wrong at all. What would you change?

Anjali: I'd integrate accessory design into the garment design process from day one. Every look should be conceived as a system - garment, bag, jewellery, headwear - with shared material language and shared structural logic. The woven interlock I developed for the jacket? Imagine that same technique at the scale of a clutch bag. Or a cuff bracelet. The technique is the throughline, not the garment category.

Arjun: That's an operational challenge, though. It means every designer needs to think across categories, not just in their lane.

Anjali: Yes. But that's what makes it haute. Ready-to-wear can afford to silo. Haute cannot.

PART V - SCENARIO CHALLENGES

TIMECODE WINDOW: [10:52 - 11:22]

Rhea: Anjali, we're going to do some scenario work now. I'm going to give you hypothetical situations and I want to see how you think through them in real-time. Ready?

Anjali: Ready.

Rhea: Scenario one. It's three weeks before a showcase. You've been developing a centerpiece look - a draped gown in raw silk - for two months. During the final fitting, the model tries to sit down and the entire back panel tears along the bias. The fabric is irreplaceable - it was a one-time batch from a handloom weaver who's now between seasons. What do you do?

Anjali: *[takes a breath]* Okay. First - don't panic. Panicking makes you stupid. Second - assess the tear. Is it along the grain or against it? If it's along the grain, I might be able to repair it with an invisible mending technique - a reweaving, essentially. I've done it before on khadi. It takes time and patience but it's possible.

If the tear is too severe for invisible mending, I'd turn it into a design feature. A visible mend. Take the tear, reinforce it with a backing fabric in a contrasting texture - maybe a metallic organza - and let the tear become an intentional element. Japanese kintsugi philosophy, but in textile. The garment becomes more interesting because of the break, not in spite of it.

And if even that doesn't work - if the tear has compromised the structural integrity of the piece and it simply cannot be worn - then three weeks is enough time to create a replacement. It won't be the same piece. It might not be as good. But it will be a piece, and it will be on time.

Rhea: Which option would you pursue first?

Anjali: The invisible mend. Always try to save the original first. The original carries the history of its making. A replacement is a new history.

Rhea: Good. Scenario two. A client commissions a bespoke piece - they want a coat inspired by traditional Kashmiri embroidery but they want it in a neon green colourway. You find the combination aesthetically offensive. What do you do?

Anjali: *[laughs]* Aesthetically offensive is strong, but I know exactly the feeling. Okay - I'd have a conversation. Not a confrontation, a conversation. I'd ask them what they're drawn to about both elements - what is it about Kashmiri embroidery that moves them, and what is it about neon green that excites them? Usually, when someone asks for something seemingly incongruent, they're reaching for a feeling they can't articulate. My job is to help them articulate it and then translate it into something that honours both impulses without being garish.

Maybe the answer isn't neon green as a base colour, but neon green as an accent - a flash of it in the embroidery thread against a more grounding base. Or maybe they want the energy of neon green - the audacity - and that energy can be achieved through a different shade or treatment. A vivid chartreuse on silk reads completely differently from neon green on polyester.

But here's the thing - if after the conversation, they still want full neon green Kashmiri embroidery? I'd make it. Beautifully. Because ultimately it's their garment, not mine. My job is to make it the best version of what they want, even if it's not what I'd choose.

Mithun: That last part - "even if it's not what I'd choose" - that's maturity. A lot of young designers struggle with that.

Anjali: I think ego has no place in bespoke. In your own collection, yes - ego is fuel. But in bespoke, the client is the author. You're the translator.

Arjun: My turn for a scenario. You're part of a three-person design team. You and another designer fundamentally disagree on the direction of a look - you want structured, they want fluid. The deadline is in four days. How do you resolve it?

Anjali: I'd ask: what's the brief? What is this look supposed to communicate to the person wearing it? Because usually, when two designers disagree on form, it's because they're interpreting the brief differently. If we can align on intent, the form often resolves itself.

But if the disagreement is genuine - if we both have valid interpretations - I'd propose a hybrid. Not a compromise, because compromise usually means everyone's unhappy. A hybrid - where we find the point of intersection between structured and fluid. Maybe the bodice is structured and the skirt is fluid. Maybe the garment is structured in silhouette but fluid in material. Tension between opposing forces is often where the most interesting design lives.

And if we truly cannot agree, and there's no hybrid that works - I'd defer to whoever has more context. If the other designer has been on this project longer, or has a closer relationship with the client or the creative director, I'd trust their instinct. I'd rather a unified vision I partially disagree with than a fractured vision nobody believes in.

Arjun: That's very pragmatic. You mentioned "defer to whoever has more context." How do you feel about hierarchy? About having a creative director above you making final calls?

Anjali: I think it's necessary. Not because I'm submissive - I'm not, ask my mother - but because great work requires decisiveness. If every decision is democratic, nothing gets decided. A creative director provides a singular lens, a consistent vision. My job isn't to replace that vision - it's to enrich it. To bring my perspective and my skills into conversation with a larger artistic direction.

I've never had a creative director before. The idea honestly excites me. Someone who can see things I can't, push me in directions I wouldn't go on my own, and tell me "no" when my instinct is wrong. That's how you grow.

Mithun: For the record, I say "no" a lot.

Anjali: Good. I want to hear "no." "No" is information. "Yes" is just agreement.

PART VI - BRAND ALIGNMENT & CULTURE FIT

TIMECODE WINDOW: [11:22 - 10:45]

Mithun: We're in the home stretch now, Anjali. Let's talk about FERRO specifically and what it means to you. Why us? You could apply to Sabyasachi. You could apply to international houses. Why a twelve-person atelier in Indiranagar that hasn't even launched yet?

Anjali: *[leans closer to camera]* Because you haven't launched yet. That's exactly why.

I don't want to join something finished. I want to join something that's still being shaped. Sabyasachi is extraordinary, but Sabyasachi's identity is established - the maximalism, the ornament, the bridal grandeur. If I joined Sabyasachi, I'd be executing someone else's completed vocabulary. Here, the vocabulary is still being written. I could contribute a word. Maybe a whole sentence.

And I - this is going to sound presumptuous, but I'll say it anyway - when I read your manifesto, I didn't feel like I was reading about a brand. I felt like I was reading about a home. The under-thirty thing, the bootstrapping, the refusal to take outside money, the obsession with craft over marketing. That's my worldview. I've been making clothes in a rented room with one dress form and a borrowed sewing machine. I know what bootstrapping feels like. I know what it means to choose quality over speed, to choose hand over machine, to choose small and deliberate over big and fast.

You're building something that says: fashion doesn't have to be a corporate machine. It can be a workshop. A family. A conversation between people who are obsessed with making beautiful things. I want to be in that conversation.

Mithun: What would you contribute to the team beyond your design skills?

Anjali: Energy. And I don't mean that in a vague, motivational-poster way. I mean - I work hard, I work long, and I bring enthusiasm that's almost annoying. I ask a lot of questions. I'm curious about everything - not just design, but production, logistics, marketing. I asked Arjun about the weaving collective's capacity because I genuinely care about whether the thing I design can actually be made and sold. I don't want to be the kind of designer who throws sketches over a wall and says "figure it out." I want to be involved end-to-end.

I'm also - and I think this matters - I'm from here. I'm from Karnataka. I grew up around the handloom traditions, the block-printing communities, the tailoring culture of this state. I have relationships with artisans - not just Raghunath and the Bagalkot weavers, but block printers in Dharwad, an embroiderer in Mysuru, a

leather worker in Bidar. Those relationships are an asset. They're a supply chain of human connection, and you can't buy that on Alibaba.

Arjun: That actually matters enormously for us. Our supply chain model is exactly that - direct artisan relationships. Your existing network is a genuine competitive advantage.

Rhea: I have a question that's less about skills and more about personality. What makes you angry?

Anjali: *[pauses, then laughs]* Waste. Waste makes me angry. Fabric waste, talent waste, time waste. I hate the fast fashion model - not just ethically, although yes, ethically - but aesthetically. The idea that you'd make a garment designed to be worn five times and thrown away is offensive to me as a maker. Every garment should earn its place in someone's life. It should be worth repairing, worth altering, worth passing down. If it's not - if it's disposable - then you haven't made a garment. You've made packaging.

Mithun: What else?

Anjali: Dishonesty in design. Brands that use words like "handcrafted" when they mean "machine-made with one hand-stitched label." Brands that claim "sustainable" because they use one organic cotton T-shirt in a collection of ninety petroleum-derived garments. Greenwashing. Heritage-washing. The commodification of craft traditions without compensating the craftspeople. That makes me genuinely angry.

Mithun: Good. You should be angry about those things. We're angry about those things.

PART VII - PRACTICAL MATTERS & CLOSING

TIMECODE WINDOW: [10:45 - 11:00]

Arjun: Let's talk practical, Anjali. If we extended an offer, what would your situation look like? Are you available to start full-time? Any constraints we should know about?

Anjali: I can start immediately. My current freelance commitments - I do some alteration work and a few custom pieces for clients - I can wrap those up within a week. I'm based in Bengaluru already, very close to Indiranagar. I don't have a notice period anywhere.

Arjun: And you're based in Bengaluru already? The atelier keeps long hours - we'd need you on-site daily once you start.

Anjali: Yes, I'm set. I live with my sister in a two-bedroom flat in Jayanagar. Twelve minutes from Indiranagar by metro, fifteen by auto, forty-five on foot. I've actually done the walk past your building. It's a good thinking route.

Arjun: Compensation expectations? I want to be transparent - we're bootstrapped, so we can't match what a Reliance-backed fashion house would offer.

Anjali: Honestly? I'm not optimising for salary right now. I'm optimising for learning and growth. I want a fair wage that lets me live in Bengaluru without stress - rent, food, materials, the occasional filter coffee. But what matters more is access. Access to the atelier, access to mentorship, access to resources and fabric libraries and artisan networks. If I'm making beautiful work and growing as a designer, the money will follow.

Arjun: That's a healthy perspective. We do offer access to our full material library, which is - Rhea, how many bolts?

Rhea: About three hundred and growing. Everything from Japanese selvage denim to handloom Chanderi to Italian wool crepe. And yes, you'd have full access. We don't lock the fabric room.

Anjali: *[quietly]* You don't lock the fabric room.

Rhea: *[laughs]* The look on your face right now - even through the screen. That was my exact reaction when I first saw the shelves.

Mithun: Anjali, I want to end with a question I ask every finalist. It's a strange question and there's no right answer. If FERRO were a garment - not a brand, not a company - if it were a single piece of clothing, what would it be?

Anjali: *[thinks for several seconds]* A coat. A long, structured, high-collared coat in raw black handloom silk. Unlined. So you can see the seams from the inside - the construction visible, honest, nothing hidden. A coat that's heavy enough to feel like protection but supple enough to move in. A coat you'd wear to a gallery opening and then walk home in the rain without worrying about it. A coat that gets better with age - that softens and creases and develops a patina that's yours and only yours.

That's FERRO. Strong, honest, getting better with time.

Mithun: *[long silence]* Rhea. Arjun. Anything else?

Rhea: I just want to say - your Ilkal interlock technique? I want to prototype it. Regardless of the outcome of this interview, I want to explore that technique in our atelier. Would you be open to that?

Anjali: I would be honoured. Genuinely.

Arjun: Nothing else from me. You've been exceptional, Anjali. Very clear, very thoughtful.

Mithun: Then I think we're done. Anjali - thank you. This was one of the best conversations I've had in this process. You'll hear from us by the end of the month. Take care.

Anjali: Thank you. All three of you. For your time, and for actually listening.

Mithun: Always. We'll be in touch.

Anjali: *[waves]* Bye!

TIMECODE WINDOW: [CALL ENDS - 11:00 IST]

POST-INTERVIEW PANEL NOTES

These notes are internal and not shared with the candidate.

Mithun S. - Founder & Creative Director

Recommendation: STRONG HIRE

Anjali demonstrated an extraordinary synthesis of intuitive design thinking and grounded practical awareness. Her portfolio submissions - particularly the Ilkal woven interlock and the constellation-mapped duo look - show a level of conceptual ambition paired with hands-on craft mastery that is exceptionally rare at her age and experience level. Her critique of our accessory programme was incisive and correct. Her cultural alignment with our manifesto is near-total, and her artisan network in Karnataka represents tangible operational value. Most importantly, she thinks in systems - not in isolated garments - and that is exactly what we need as we build the house's design language from the ground up.

Rhea Kapoor - Head of Design & Pattern Architecture

Recommendation: STRONG HIRE

Technically, she is the strongest candidate I've interviewed in Salon 05. Her drape-first methodology aligns perfectly with our studio process. Her understanding of fabric behaviour - particularly her distinction between handloom and machine-spun textiles - indicates a material sensitivity that typically takes years to develop. The Ilkal interlock is a genuine innovation and I want it in our first collection. Her honesty about past failures (the machine-cotton buckle incident) shows self-awareness and growth capacity. She needs refinement in production-scale thinking, but that's teachable. Her instinct is not.

Arjun Desai - Head of Operations & Brand Strategy

Recommendation: HIRE

Operationally sound. She understands constraints, works within budgets, maintains artisan relationships, and respects deadlines (even if she pushes them). Her response to the team disagreement scenario demonstrated maturity and pragmatism beyond her years. Her willingness to defer to creative direction while still advocating for her perspective is the ideal balance for a junior designer in a small team. She's also local, available immediately, and has realistic compensation expectations. Low-risk, high-upside hire.

PANEL CONSENSUS: Proceed to offer.

Offer Letter Target: Before 31st October 2026

Start Date: November 2026

FERRO - ATELIER BENGALURU

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